comes from experience, as much as philosophical knowledge or *jnana*, which comes from study and reading, a guru can share his experience as a guide and model to the disciple. The best kind of guru is usually an inspirational teacher, a source of wisdom and instruction, a guide moulding the spiritual evolution of the disciple, an elder who imparts his values and a philosopher who reveals the meaning of life to the attentive seeker. Guru means 'dispeller of darkness'; the exalted place of the guru in Hindu thinking reflects the fact that while a mother merely gives us physical birth, a guru ensures our spiritual rebirth. Not all self-anointed gurus are, however, worthy of the appellation.

India is full of gurus; some are figures of great learning and erudition in the religious texts, some are capable of performing mystical and magical feats beyond rational explanation, and some merely impart a quiet wisdom that their followers find inspirational. Such gurus attract followings in the millions, and many have established ashrams to which their devotees flock, and in which many live either permanently or for regular periods, either conducting religious and spiritual practices, or performing social services in the name of their guru's order. But there are also, in the same domain yet of a different order, charlatans, poseurs and tricksters, in what has been dubbed 'the God Market', who woo the credulous with simplistic ideas of spirituality and amass huge fortunes at the expense of the gullible. These include a female guru who wears red mini-skirts and offers homilies on love, a baba who sits in a tree and dispenses benediction through a touch of his foot, and another who receives the world in his naked glory and whose ultimate blessing comes in the opportunity to grasp his exposed male member. Much of this has nothing to do with Hinduism, except that it is a manifestation of the Hindu's eternal search for spiritual truth, in whatever form it can be found.

Many of the devotees of these godmen are not Hindus. Equally, some of these godmen are not Hindu but count Hindus among their followers. It is important to note that the hold godmen have on their followers is not purely a function of religious devotion; rather it has a lot to do with a sense of drift in society, an aimlessness and hopelessness that requires a religious anchor. Clinching evidence for this proposition came in the